

4.4 UNDERSTANDING GOD'S ATTRIBUTES: ANALOGICAL PREDICATION

When speaking of God's attributes, such as his *having a will*, Aquinas employs terms familiar from their human applications. God is *omniscient*, and so supremely *intelligent*; God is *omnibenevolent*, which is to say, all-good; and God is *omnipotent*, or powerful without limit. It is natural to assume, then, that God simply has, in boundless measure, the very attributes we find exemplified by human beings who are intelligent, good, or powerful. Indeed, when we conceptualize Aquinas's God, it is easy and almost unavoidable to do so by considering God to be, in a certain sense, a person, or person-like, a being manifesting just the attributes we habitually regard as constitutive of personhood. God is the subject of mental states, has beliefs (all true beliefs, of course), knows things as we know things, and is a conscious living being just as we are conscious living beings. Aquinas's God seems to be, in fact, a person—a perfect person, to be sure, but a person nonetheless.

If there is something unavoidable about approaching Aquinas's God in these terms, there is also something deeply problematic in doing so. One of God's most primitive impersonal attributes renders all such talk hard to fathom: God is simple, absolutely simple, whereas no person is or could be simple.

As we have already seen, at its root, this one characterization already puts significant stress on our conception of God as having diverse attributes, and we have also seen (§4.3.1) that Aquinas can indeed speak of God as simple, because a simple thing can be described by using coreferential terms rather than synonymous ones. Now, however, our worries can be taken to a higher level of difficulty. Given God's absolute simplicity, it seems fair to ask by what right Aquinas permits himself to speak of God as having 'attributes' or 'properties' in the first instance. God is, according to Aquinas, identical with his essence; everything said truly of God's intrinsic nature obtains of God necessarily and immutably. So, when speaking of God on the one hand, and God's attributes on the other, Aquinas already seems to implicate God in some kind of fundamental complexity of a sort that is plainly incompatible with divine simplicity. Any given person has the property of being good in some measure, though the degree of goodness in a person's life will vary as it grows sometimes greater and slackens off at other times. Minimally, the degree of goodness a person manifests is accidental. No person is identical with her goodness; unlike God, then, persons exhibit complexity even in the very exemplification of their attributes. We are inclined to say that a person *has* some degree of goodness. But we do not say that a person *is* the same as goodness itself. God's simplicity precludes our talking this way. According to Aquinas, God is goodness itself.

Now, if we think of persons as necessarily complex, then we are not at liberty to conceive of God as a person. If we are not at liberty to conceive of God as a person, however, then neither are we entitled, at least not without some special pleading, to regard God as manifesting personal attributes. If, however, the attributes of goodness and intelligence as applied to God are not personal attributes, are not the sort of attributes we understand as belonging paradigmatically and exclusively to persons, then we shall have to admit that we do not know exactly what we mean when we ascribe them to God. We do not even rightly conceive of them as "attributes" of God, since God is not a subject with attributes but, rather, a seamless being whose nature finds any division repugnant.

Already, then, we may be losing our bearings when we come to characterize God in the terms employed by Aquinas in his grand derivation. Moreover, matters are becoming still worse. Consider Professor

Brightlight. She is, let us say, intelligent, powerful, and good. Of course, she is a human being and thus imperfect in all sorts of ways. Still, she is truly intelligent, powerful, and good. She can be contrasted with Professor Scurrilous: he is intelligent and powerful as well, but he is also morally rotten and so not, in this respect, at all good. So much seems plainly possible; some people are intelligent and powerful but not good; others are powerful but neither good nor intelligent; and so on for the various other combinations of these attributes. Such variability shows conclusively, it seems, that these attributes are distinct. That is, as applied to persons, being powerful, being good, and being intelligent are altogether different traits. Because these traits are not even extensionally equivalent, they are certainly not identical.

Now, however, consider the applications of these traits to Aquinas's God. This God is *absolutely* simple. Indeed, as is perfectly plain in the master derivation, God is identical with God's essence (recall stages 19, 26, 32, 40, and 50, where Aquinas repeatedly asserts this sort of identification). It follows, then, that in the case of God the attributes *being good*, *being powerful*, *being intelligent*, *being alive*, and so on for any other attribute correctly ascribed to God (if indeed it is in the first instance appropriate to speak of attributes in this domain) cannot be distinct. Instead, they must all be distinct ways of characterizing one and the same thing.

If we grant that so much is cogent, by relying on a doctrine of non-synonymous but coreferential terms, we do not yet really address the root problem for Aquinas. For now a deeper problem emerges and threatens to undermine any understanding of what these coreferential terms are even supposed to mean. If the attributes designated by ordinary predicates such as *good* and *intelligent* are the same in God but diverse in human beings, then the attributes we ascribe to God are not—indeed, cannot be—the same attributes we ascribe to human beings. Yet if they are not the same attributes, and only happen to be named the same, then surely we are at sea when we pretend to be conceptualizing anything about God. It is as if, having characterized Joseph Stalin as an uncommonly humble man, someone confronted with overwhelming evidence of his brash arrogance and haughty pride insisted by way of response that Stalin was *definitely* humble, even supremely humble, but that *humility* as applied to Stalin meant something special and distinct.

Humility in Stalin's case, the response continues, was something altogether unique and not to be compared to the pedestrian sort of humility manifested by ordinary citizens. He was, after all, no ordinary man. He was Stalin. Well, perhaps. But we can hardly even begin to agree or disagree with his sycophant, because we do not yet have any understanding of what his claim about Stalin was supposed to mean.

This case illustrates that, if we are intent upon reserving absolute simplicity for God, then we are hard-pressed to understand what it means to ascribe to him attributes normally understood to be distinct. The first thing to notice in this connection is that God's attributes are not the same attributes as those ascribed to Professors Brightlight and Scurrilous—or to any other human being who ever lived or will live. Perhaps that is so obvious as to need no proof, though a simple one is available, employing just two attributes for illustration:

1. If God is absolutely simple, then God's *goodness* and *knowledge* are identical.
2. God is absolutely simple.
3. Therefore, God's *goodness* and *knowledge* are identical.
4. If it is possible for *goodness* and *knowledge* to diverge as applied to ordinary humans, then *goodness* and *knowledge* as applied to humans are not identical.
5. It is possible for *goodness* and *knowledge* as applied to ordinary humans to diverge (for it is actually so: some people are knowledgeable but not good).
6. Therefore, *goodness* and *knowledge* as applied to God and as applied to ordinary humans are not identical.

From this conclusion, it is easy to derive the further conclusion that no attribute applied to human beings can be identical with an attribute applied to God.

7. Divine goodness has the property of being identical with knowledge.
8. Human goodness lacks the property of being identical with knowledge.

9. If x and y have distinct properties, then x and y are not the same things.
10. Therefore, human and divine goodness are not the same thing.

What holds of goodness holds of every other attribute as well, because this example is chosen arbitrarily. If we are inclined to think that we know what human goodness is (at least more or less), or that we know what human knowledge is (again, at least more or less), then what we fail to know is what these traits are in the case of God. All we seem to know is that they are not all the same traits we find showing up in persons of our acquaintance. Hence, we might now be tempted to conclude that what holds for Stalin holds for God: we do not really have any idea at all what these claims about God mean. We are not, in truth, even in a position to agree or disagree; for we do not so much as understand them.

If there is a fault here, it lies with Aquinas. It was, after all, his contention that God is absolutely simple. We have merely traced out the consequences of his claim. Still, his claim about simplicity was not idle: without it, much of the rest of his derivation could not have moved forward. So we find him in an uncomfortable dilemma: either he must withdraw his characterization of God as absolutely simple, and so abandon his derivation of God's attributes at a very early stage (stage 14, to be exact), or he must leave simplicity intact at the expense of rendering the very terms of that derivation utterly inexplicable. Neither alternative seems a happy one for Aquinas. Either his derivation fails or it employs terms whose very meanings are mysterious to the point of incomprehensibility.

Aquinas rejects this dilemma as false. He argues that it turns on an unsustainable semantic dichotomy according to which two terms either mean just the same or are utterly disjoint in their meanings. He thinks that he has available to him a *tertium quid*—a third alternative between these two extremes. It is not that, for example, 'goodness' as applied to God and 'goodness' as applied to Professor Brightlight either mean the same thing (are, in Aquinas's terms, *univocal*) or mean utterly distinct things (are *equivocal*). Rather, 'goodness' as applied to Professor Brightlight indeed means something different from what 'goodness' as applied to God means, but these terms are nevertheless systematically

related in ways that make each of their meanings individually clear and the relations of their meanings to one another fully explicable.

In Aquinas's terms, 'good' in the sentence (a) "God is good" and 'good' in the sentence (b) "Professor Brightlight is good" are *analogical*. In fact, the predicate 'is good' in (b) is derived from its primary application in (a), so that we may understand them both as distinct but perfectly understandable, each in its own domain. If that is right, then there is no parallel between God and Stalin: whereas Stalin's lackey obfuscated when pressed, Aquinas advances a theory that deserves a hearing, both in the context under consideration and more generally as an approach to the systematic relations we may find between discrete but nonequivocal meanings or, in a more metaphysical mode, between properties that bear interestingly asymmetric dependence relations to other more fundamental properties.

To understand Aquinas's point of view, it is first necessary to understand some of the technical machinery and terminology he develops to handle challenges of the sort now being put to him. Whatever else may be true of him, he is fully aware of just the worry now being entertained. In fact, he himself is the first to insist that no predicates are applied to God and creatures univocally:

As is clear from what has been said, there is nothing in God that is not the divine being itself; and this is not the case with other things. Nothing, therefore, can be predicated of God and other things univocally. (SCG I.32.3/285)

Here Aquinas argues forthrightly, relying directly on his conception of divine simplicity, that nothing is predicated univocally of God and creatures. It follows, again, that 'good' as applied to God does not mean the same thing as 'good' as applied to human beings.

This can be further appreciated by focusing on Aquinas's own very careful analysis of univocal predication. By "univocally" in this and other connections he means something quite precise:

a and b are univocally $\varphi =_{df}$ (i) a is φ ; (ii) b is φ ; and (iii) the accounts of φ -ness in ' a is φ ' and ' b is φ ' are the same.

So, for example, 'round' as applied to a penny and a circus ring is univocal. That is, the account corresponding to 'round' in these two applications will be precisely the same. Aquinas is denying, then, that this sort of sameness of account will obtain in the case of, for example, 'good,' or of any other predicate ascribed to creatures and God. If we construe such accounts as definitions that capture the real meanings of the predicates whose accounts they are, then it will also follow that the meanings of these predicates will diverge in these distinct applications. Thus, 'God is good' does not say of God what 'Professor Brightlight is good' says of Professor Brightlight.

That would seemingly lead to the conclusion that 'good' in these various applications is *equivocal*—that is, that the meanings are distinct—with the result that we really do not have a clear conception of God's attributes. Aquinas disagrees. Just after denying univocity, he is quick to point out that predicates do not attach to God and creatures merely equivocally. For then we really would be without a clue as to the meanings of terms applied to God:

It is also a fact that a name is predicated of some being uselessly unless through that name we understand something of the being. But, if names are said of God and creatures in a purely equivocal way, we understand nothing of God through those names; for the meanings of those names are known to us solely to the extent that they are said of creatures. In vain, therefore, would it be said or proved of God that he is a being, good, or the like. (SCG I.33.6/295)

This seems just the right conclusion to draw, given Aquinas's conception of equivocity, which is:

a and b are equivocally $\phi =_{df}$ (i) a is ϕ ; (ii) b is ϕ ; and (iii) the accounts of ϕ -ness in ' a is ϕ ' and ' b is ϕ ' have nothing in common and do not overlap in any way.

So, for example, 'bank,' as applied to the sides of rivers and to buildings where money is saved and borrowed, is equivocal. No one should

think that there is a real connection between banks and the sides of rivers merely because they are called by the same name. As Aquinas notes above, if there were only this much connection between the predicates applied to God and creatures, then the entire derivation of God's attributes would have been "in vain."

What is striking about Aquinas's approach to this issue is his clear and defensible recognition that univocity and equivocality are not exhaustive options. This can be appreciated in a formal way by attending to the precise definitions of these terms: univocal predicates have the same accounts, whereas equivocal terms have accounts with "nothing in common" and so "do not overlap in any way." A moment's reflection makes patently clear that there is a third possibility, namely that some terms are neither univocal, because their accounts are not precisely the same, nor equivocal, because their accounts, although not the same, overlap and have some things, perhaps a great many things, in common with one another.

This third way is what Aquinas calls *analogical* predication:

From what we have said, therefore, it remains that the names said of God and creatures are predicated neither univocally nor equivocally but analogically, that is, according to an order or reference to something one. (SCG I.34.1/297)

It should be stressed immediately that his conception of analogy is a stipulatively defined notion, one that has to be sharply distinguished from the contemporary notion of analogy, considered as a linguistic trope, namely as a certain kind of comparison (for example, "Her skin was as supple as the petal of a spring lily"). Rather, Aquinas intends his notion of analogical predication to occupy just that space between equivocal and univocal predication left open by their precise definitions. His general approach to analogical predication, stated formally, is:

a and b are analogically φ =_{df} (i) a is φ ; (ii) b is φ ; (iii) a and b are literally φ ; and (iv) a and b are neither univocally nor equivocally φ .

In appealing to literalness, we mean to rule out metaphor. Though the distinction between the literal and metaphorical is notoriously difficult

to analyze, it is perhaps clear enough in practice. Still, even if we help ourselves to the notion of something's being *literally* ϕ , the definition tells us little about how Aquinas conceives of analogical predication in particular cases. As soon as one pursues the matter further, it becomes clear that his approach turns very technical very quickly. He distinguishes several varieties of analogical predication, one of which is especially relevant to his conception of the way predications of God and creatures are related. This may be called *ordered analogy*:

a and b are analogically ϕ in an ordered way =_{df} (i) a is ϕ ; (ii) b is ϕ ; and (iii) the account of ϕ in ' b is ϕ ' necessarily makes reference to the account of ϕ in ' a is ϕ ' in an asymmetrical way.

If we think of God's goodness and the goodness of creatures along these lines, then we can finally arrive at Aquinas's full theory of their relation.

Although initially perhaps a bit overwhelming, Aquinas's doctrine can be understood by a simple illustration. Consider the following sentences:

- a. To be *healthy* is to flourish in mind and body.
- b. Albert's complexion is *healthy*.
- c. Albert's diet is *healthy*.

Two things should be clear immediately: (1) 'healthy' as it appears in these sentences does not mean exactly the same thing; and (2) the appearances of 'healthy' in these sentences are somehow related. That is, 'healthy' in these applications is neither univocal nor equivocal. It is not univocal, because we cannot insert the account of 'healthy' in (a) into (b) or (c), nor can the accounts presupposed in (b) and (c) be substituted for one another. (In [c], 'healthy' might be paraphrased as "is productive of health," and in [b] as "is indicative of health.") Still, it is plain that these are not cases of equivocity, because there are clear connections between the applications ('healthy' is not like 'bank'). Thus, we have neither equivocity nor univocity but, rather, analogy.

The kind of analogy we have in this case also helps illustrate ordered analogy, because if we want to understand (b) and (c), we have to

appeal to the notion of being 'healthy' in (a). Thus, for instance, to say that Albert's diet is healthy is just to say that he eats the kinds of foods that tend to produce health in him, foods that tend to help him flourish in mind and body. So, though the *account* or definition of 'healthy' in (a) makes no appeal to the accounts of 'healthy' in (b) and (c), their accounts *must* appeal to the account of 'healthy' in (a) if they are to be correct. This captures the *asymmetry* that Aquinas understands in cases of ordered analogy. The non-primary cases depend on the primary cases, though the primary cases do not depend on the non-primary cases.

This is, then, the circumstance Aquinas envisages between God and creatures. Although it is not obvious, as it is in the case with 'healthy,' he thinks there exists the same form of dependence of non-primary on primary in these applications of 'good':

- a. God is good.
- b. Professor Brightlight is good.

To provide an account of 'good' in (b), it will be necessary, according to Aquinas, ultimately to provide an account of 'good' in (a). If we attend carefully to the derivation of goodness in Aquinas's master argument, then we see instantly that the notion of goodness as applied to God is rooted in God's complete perfection and actuality. Ultimately, then, to understand goodness even as it is applied to creatures (that is, to be able to provide a full analysis of goodness in any application outside of God) it will be necessary to understand goodness in terms of God's perfection and complete actuality. This, then, is the sense in which ordered analogy appeals to the notion of a *source*: it is God, as the ultimate source, according to Aquinas, to whom we must look if we are ever to put ourselves in a position of understanding fully what goodness—or any other shared predicate—consists in.

Aquinas cautions, however, that it does not follow that we have no inkling of goodness before we come to learn something of God's goodness. After all, a great many people, including a great many to whom Aquinas addresses the *Summa contra gentiles*, have no knowledge of God's goodness. Not only may they not believe in the existence of Aquinas's God, but they may even positively deny that such a being is

coherent. So much Aquinas appreciates. In fact, although he thinks of God as the ultimate source of goodness, Aquinas supposes that we first experience goodness, however imperfectly, in other things. In keeping with the indirect character of his proofs for God's existence, Aquinas thinks we first experience the effects of God's activity and then, on the basis of that experience, come indirectly to an understanding of God's existence and nature. He concludes:

Because we come to a knowledge of God from other things, the reality in names said of God and other things belongs by priority in God according to his mode of being, but the meaning of the name belongs to God by posteriority. And so he is said to be named from his effects. (SCG I.34.6/298)

Thus, just as we know of God's existence as the ultimate and necessary explanation of what we have experienced after we know the existence of things encountered in sense perception, so we come to know God's nature by grasping the effects of that nature in our daily lives.

For example, if we see that some human has been good, has done something fine and noble, then we learn the meanings of the terms used to describe her behavior. However, says Aquinas, we do not understand those terms fully before we understand them in their primary applications, because they are, though it is unknown to us, non-primary instances of ordered analogy. For example, when, as children, we learned to drink milk because it was healthy, we had some notion of what was meant by the locution, though we were not in a position, if pressed, to offer up an account of what it was that made milk healthy, or even of what it was for a living being—a person, a dog, or a tree—to be healthy. Surely we had some clue, but it does not follow that we had or needed to have complete mastery of the concept in order to apply the term correctly. At any rate, it is not the case that we can offer a defensible analysis of every word we understand at the level of linguistic meaning. In this sense, Aquinas is right to urge that we may learn the meanings of the words we use to some level of adequacy without knowing how the concepts they express are to be

understood at the end of the day. What, after all, is the correct analysis of 'goodness'?